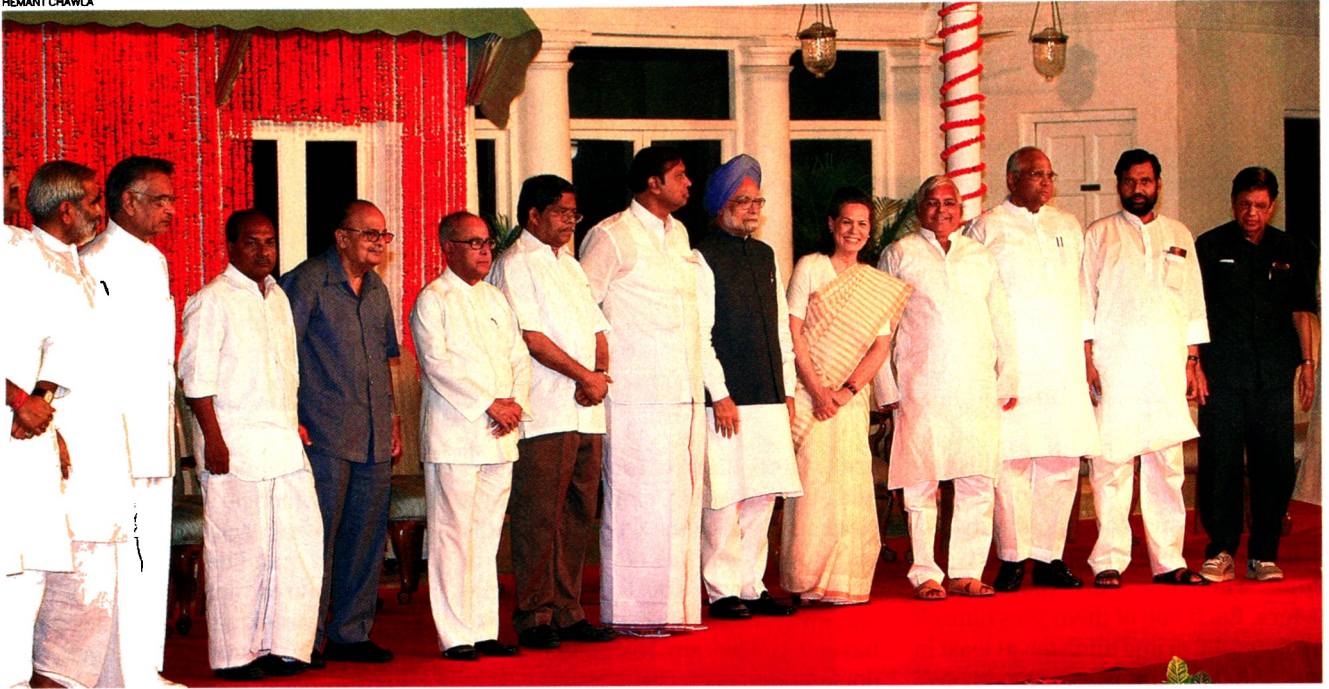


IN A COALITION STRUCTURE LIKE THE UPA, FIXING THE CHAIN OF COMMAND IS AN EVEN MORE DIFFICULT TASK

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THE AVERAGE AGE OF MANMOHAN'S CABINET IS 67. EIGHT OF THE MINISTERS ARE OVER 70 WHILE 17 ARE OVER 60.

who can lead, earn respect and confidence of the people, the temporary leadership vacuum has already caused enough damage to the institution of the prime minister. Does it mean that the votes will be sought on the basis of performance of the Government and not in the name of a leader who delivered?

THE HEIR LOOMS

The Congress party is already whispering in terms of legitimising the hereditary right of Rahul Gandhi to lead the party during the next elections. Some of the senior leaders of the Congress are busy projecting him as the inevitable prime ministerial candidate. But his name will take off only if the party is in a position to win more than the 150-odd seats it holds in the

Lok Sabha now. He has been on road shows but the results have not been encouraging if one goes by the seats won by the Congress during the last few Assembly elections. For long Rahul has argued that he wants to wait before he is ready to don the leadership mantle. Now it seems he is running out of time. Although Congress leaders rule out the projection of Rahul as the prime ministerial candidate just yet, the inevitable may just have been hastened. "There is no political fallout of the prime minister's illness," said Digvijay Singh, Congress general secretary. "As for pressure on Rahul, it is a question of timing which the Congress president will decide. The prime minister's illness is not a factor. Remember Sheilaji won an election after a bypass surgery," he added. The

Congress needs Manmohan for its succession plan to pave the way for Rahul's ascension. The conventional wisdom, according to party sources, is that if a Congress-led government comes back to power, Rahul would be groomed to take over from Manmohan at an appropriate time. The party has invested a lot in the Manmohan legacy; party strategists see his credentials as an economist as the right leverage in times of recession. What is being sold to the voter is Manmohan's governance along with the promise of a youthful Rahul Gandhi. "This was to be the John McCain-Sarah Palin package designed to trump Advani's campaign focussing on experience," said a Rajya Sabha member from the Congress.

And if Manmohan decides to call it a day, the allies are already waiting in the wings to strike a better deal. The NCP has floated the Pawar balloon, the Samajwadi Party is not willing to yield any ground and other allies like the DMK and PMK are flexing their muscles. Soon after the prime minister went in for surgery, Sharad Pawar who had earlier announced that he would not be contesting for the Lok Sabha in the